Tables and Chairs

By Stanley Rutherford

ALICE: Howard says that –

NAOMI: I don't care what Howard says...if Howard wants to say something, Howard can say if for himself...isn't that right Howie? (glares at Howard)

ALICE: Howard is very shy.

NAOMI: (screams) Speak, Howard! Speak!

ALICE: Howard is the man I love.

INTRODUCTION

Every marriage starts with a lot of hope and dreams about a life-long association filled with love and togetherness. . . . . . HOWEVER . . . . committing to a long term relationship like marriage solely on the basis of that feeling of love is a mistake. Or maybe it's not. Howard and Alice are like . . . . like Peanut Butter and Jelly, like Ham and Eggs – like . . . . Tables and Chairs by Stanley Rutherford.

NAOMI: Alice, Howard has been married about seventeen times, maybe more...

ALICE: Howard is the man of my dreams.

NAOMI: The longest marriage lasted about seven weeks, the shortest exactly 18 hours...remember her Howard? Gloria Garton? The ventriloquist? And then there was Mary Louise Menderman and Mieu-Mieu-Rohrbach and Allison Kildaire...

ALICE: (pause) Naomi...Howard has asked me to be his bride.

NAOMI: (sigh) Oh, Alice...

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ALICE: Howard has asked me to join him in eternal wedlock.

NAOMI: Alice, you need professional help.

ALICE: Howard wants to sanctify our love.

NAOMI: Alice, Howard will get what he wants from you and then he'll dismiss you.

ALICE: He wants to marry me.

NAOMI: He wants to marry everyone...it's his plan for world peace. A world with one husband and five billion wives. Five billion wedding ceremonies with five billion wedding presents. Howard plans to return all of the wedding presents and use the cash to eliminate all international debt.

ALICE: (gasps) Isn't that wonderful!

NAOMI: It's sick.

ALICE: Howard will win the Nobel Prize.

NAOMI: Howard will be indicted for polygamy. Howard will spend the rest of his life behind bars: handcuffed, tethered, and gagged. (pause, gently to Alice) Alice, Howard is a psychopath.

ALICE: I love Howard.

NAOMI: Howard is a sociopath. He's a barbarian who preys on unsuspecting women, especially those with a healthy bank account.

ALICE: I have bags of money.

NAOMI: That's what Howard wants.

ALICE: Howard can have it all.

NAOMI: He wants it all.

ALICE: Isn't Howard wonderful?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NAOMI: Alice, Howard is a Casanova who has ruined the lives of countless women…Mieu-Mieu Rohrbach, Mary Louise Menderman…

ALICE: I love Howard.

NAOMI: Claudia Grierson, Melonie Camberwell, Dottie Leachman, Mimi Nash…

ALICE: Naomi…Howard and I are going to be married this evening. And I would like you to be my maid of honor.

NAOMI: (quickly) I'm going to be having major surgery.

ALICE: Naomi…

NAOMI: Major exploratory surgery.

ALICE: It would mean so much to us both.

NAOMI: I am going to be in the depths of anesthesia.

ALICE: We want it to be special…just Howard and I and our very special friends, Naomi and Spencer…just the four of us…our family.

NAOMI: (dryly) I wish I'd known sooner.

ALICE: We wanted it to be a surprise…Howard wants me to wear his mother's wedding dress…

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: The very dress that she wore when she married Howard's father.

NAOMI: Alice, Howard wants everybody to wear his mother's wedding dress. I'm surprised he's not going to wear it himself. Everyone else has: Mieu-Mieu Rohrbach, Melonie Camberwell, Gloria Garton. Have you ever seen Howard's mother's wedding dress?

ALICE: Howard wants it to be a surprise.

NAOMI: Alice, Howard's mother was a saint, God knows…but she had a hump, a very large hump, back here…(points)…and so does the dress…you'll have

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

to pad yourself to fill it out. (Alice is starting to have doubts) Alice, we have known Howard since infancy…and he's the same now as he was then. He's still an infant… Alice, Howard needs help, he's not self-sufficient…he can't get up in the morning, and Spencer and I have graciously taken responsibility for his care and protection…

ALICE: Howard says that he takes care of you.

NAOMI: We take care of him. It's a long story, Alice, awfully long and awfully tragic. Howard needed someone to take care of him after his mother died. He couldn't take care of himself, and so Spencer and I adopted him. Howard is our son. We'll be your in-laws if you marry him.

ALICE: (screaming) Howard…Howard…Howard talk to me! (long pause, moves to Naomi for comfort) I don't know why I love him.

NAOMI: Honey, love is a heartache. You're better off without it. It's overrated. It's an enzyme. You can get the same feeling from eating chocolate.

ALICE: (pause, stunned) I didn't know.

NAOMI: I didn't either. I had to learn.

ALICE: And I've watched and I've listened trying to learn the movements, the attitudes, the right things to say and do, when to say it, when to keep it to myself…

NAOMI: (comforting) Honey, you're doing just fine.

ALICE: I'm not a real person. I'm a pretend person.

NAOMI: You're a very nice person, Alice.

ALICE: (hysterical) I am not a person!

NAOMI: Honey, you've got to relax.

ALICE: I have no personality!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NAOMI: Alice, honey, you don't need a personality to be a person.

ALICE: I want a personality.

NAOMI: Personality is a completely overrated commodity.

ALICE: I want to be like you. You're fun.

NAOMI: I am?

ALICE: Everyone thinks you're fun.

NAOMI: I didn't know that.

ALICE: I want to be fun too.

NAOMI: You are fun.

ALICE: No, I'm not…I'm neurotic.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: (loudly) I'm neurotic!

NAOMI: (louder) I don't like that word!

ALICE: (screams into Naomi's face) Neurotic!

NAOMI: Alice, there are certain words that I simply cannot tolerate being used in my presence, and that word it one of them. It is a bad word, Alice.

ALICE: I'm manic-depressive.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: I'm schizophrenic.

NAOMI: (loudly) Bad words! Bad words! Bad, bad, "psychology" words.

ALICE: I disappear with other people leave the room. I vanish. I am a planet. I have no light source of my own. I need other people, light-giving people off of whom I can reflect.

NAOMI: You need to eat more chocolate.

ALICE: I need Howard.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NAOMI: (annoyed) Alice…

ALICE: I need you. (she opens her arms to Naomi)

NAOMI: (embracing Alice) Alice…

ALICE: I'd like you to be my sister.

NAOMI: Alice, I don't like that word.

ALICE: I never had a sister.

NAOMI: It's not you I don't like, it's the institution.

ALICE: We'd be so close.

NAOMI: We are close.

ALICE: Even closer.

NAOMI: Let's just be friends.

ALICE: (gasps, thrilled) I've never had a friend. I want both of you to be in my wedding so very much.

NAOMI: Honey, I'm having major surgery.

ALICE: Couldn't you have it tomorrow?

NAOMI: It's urgent…it has to be done as soon as possible.

ALICE: Maybe we could fit it in before the wedding…

NAOMI: We are not going to fit it in before the wedding.

ALICE: …cut you open, move things around, sew you up…So why don't we have major surgery and then a little supper -- a nice postoperative, prenuptial supper…

NAOMI: I don't think I'm going to be up for it.

ALICE: And then we'll have the wedding!

NAOMI: And then we'll have the consummation, the disenchantment, the lamentations, and then we'll have the divorce.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ALICE: (oblivious) I'm so happy.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: I want to have babies.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: And I want them to look like Howard.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: I want them to look like Howard.

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: Howard's eyes and Howard's nose…

NAOMI: Alice…

ALICE: I want them to sound like Howard and smell like Howard…

NAOMI: You need professional help.

ALICE: I had never experienced real life, I mean real, real, life, until that wonderful moment when I opened my door and saw this beautiful mad standing on my doorstep and then he smiled and I was terrified, my heard was pounding, I was confused…and then he asked me if I wanted to buy a vacuum cleaner…

NAOMI: He's stolen it.

ALICE: …but I didn't need a vacuum cleaner…

NAOMI: No one does.

ALICE: I already had a vacuum cleaner, and then he said his name was Howard and I said my name was Alice, and I was paralyzed with fear and joy, and then he asked if he could come it and then he said he wanted to marry me and make a million babies, and then he told me about his friends. He said that you had fallen on hard times and had no place to

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

live and needed a place to stay for a few days and maybe, he said, that I might have a place for you to stay and maybe I might be able to spare some food. (pause) I was thrilled. I'd always wanted someone to live with me, someone who needed me, because my life had been nothing but pain and loneliness and everyday was solitude and terror in the face of an enormous and terrifying world…I had nothing to hold on to, no one to tell me that things were going to be all right until I met Howard and got to know his wonderful friends.

NAOMI: Alice, Howard and Spencer and I are not nice people. We are not the kind of people you want to have lying around your home. We don't have a real home. We're on the run, we're fugitives. We're wanted in all 50 states…shoplifting, petty theft, extortion…There are posters out with pictures of us. It was the Howard-the-Evangelist episode that pushed us over the edge…an awful period, Alice. We'd set up a nine hundred number and Howard was passing himself off as a television evangelist…call Howard and find salvation. And you'd dial the nine hundred number and get a prerecorded message from Howard. And "inspirational" message…it was quite lucrative…They're after us for fraud. Alice, we've had to resort to a life of crime.

ALICE: (confused, then enthusiastic) I want you to know that you can stay here forever. I will hide you and feed you and we'll create our own beautiful world safe from the outside.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Stanley Rutherford
Book: Scenes and Monologs from the Best New Plays
ISBN: 0916260933
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date(Month/Year): Sep 1992

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier – HI (Female)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY